

Estate Manager — Troubleshooting Guide

Common problems, what they mean, and how to fix them.

Related documents

- [USER MANUAL.md](#) — day-to-day usage of the system.
- [CONFIGURATION.md](#) — starting the app, accounts, and integrations.
- [DEPLOYMENT.md](#) — hosting the system online for demos.

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1. The app won't start

Symptom: `npm run dev` errors immediately.

- Check the **Node.js** version: `node -v` (needs 16+).
 - Run `npm install` in the project root (and in `server/` / `client/` if freshly cloned).
 - Read the full error — the most common cause is a **port already in use** (see [#10](#)).
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2. "Not Found" on pages or after a feature update

Symptom: A page loads but a section keeps returning **Not Found** (for example Reports showing `404` on `summary / period / rent-ledger`).

Cause: The API server loads its code **once at startup**. If it was started before new routes existed (or while an upload/update was in progress), it is still serving the old code.

Fix — restart the server:

1. Stop it: `Ctrl+C` in the `npm run dev` terminal (or kill the process list).
2. Run `npm run dev` again.
3. Re-check the previously failing page.

If you just updated or copied new code into the project, always restart before investigating anything else.

3. Can't reach the app at all

Symptom: Browser says "can't reach this page" for <http://localhost:5173>.

1. Confirm the server processes are running:

```
ps aux | grep -E 'vite|node.*index'
```

2. If nothing is listed, the server isn't running — start it (see [CONFIGURATION.md](#)).
3. Verify the ports respond:

```
curl -s -o /dev/null -w "%{http_code}\n" http://localhost:5173 # web app
curl -s -o /dev/null -w "%{http_code}\n" http://localhost:4000/api/auth/login
```

The web app should return `200` ; the API a response from the login endpoint.

4. If the ports listen but the page is broken, check the terminal log for errors and restart.

4. New features / report endpoints missing

Symptom: The web app has a new button/page, but the API responds **Not Found** for it (e.g. Reports).

- The API needs a **restart** after code changes — see [#2](#).
- After restarting, the affected page should work immediately.

5. Login problems

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
"Incorrect username or password"	Typo / wrong password	Re-type; watch for Caps Lock. Use Change password if forgotten (old password required).
User disabled	Account was disabled by an admin	Contact an admin to Enable the account (Users tab).
Password lost & no admin help	Data reset needed	Reset demo data — see CONFIGURATION.md → Backup & reset . Warning: wipes all recorded data.

6. SMS shows "simulated" and no message arrives

Normal. Until real Africa's Talking credentials are configured, every message is recorded as **simulated** and nothing is actually sent — this is by design ([CONFIGURATION.md → Simulated mode](#)).

To send real SMS:

1. Open **Settings → SMS — Africa's Talking**.
2. Set your **Username**, **API key** and a **Sender ID**.
3. Turn **Save** on (and switch **Sandbox** off when ready for live SMS).
4. Use **Send a test message** to confirm delivery.

If a test fails with credentials set:

- Double-check the API key and username.

- In **Sandbox mode**, ensure the recipient was added as an allowed sandbox number in your Africa's Talking dashboard.
 - Verify the sender ID matches what your Africa's Talking account allows.
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7. Emails fail to send

When the email badge shows **Failed X** with an error, check:

- **Authentication** — username/password wrong or the account requires an app-specific password (e.g. Gmail "app passwords").
 - **Port/TLS** — most providers use port **587 + STARTTLS**; check which your provider requires.
 - **From address** — must be allowed by the provider for the account.
 - **Spam folder** — a successful send may land in spam.
 - Once fixed, re-test from **Settings → Send a test message**.
-

8. Renewal reminders never arrive

1. **Reminders are simulated** until credentials exist — see [#6](#).
2. Confirm the **look-ahead** setting is meaningful (Settings → *Send expiry reminders N months ahead*).
3. Confirm the lease's **end date** and **renewal frequency** are correct (Lease Renewals).
4. Confirm the lease is still **active** and not already marked *notified*.
5. Trigger the pass manually: **Notifications → ► Run automated reminders now**, then check the Notifications page for new entries.

Reminders run automatically at **server start** and every **6 hours** — an on-demand run skips leases already notified.

9. Reading rejected as "lower than previous"

Symptom: Utilities refuses a water/electricity reading.

A new reading must be **≥ the previous reading** for the same unit + utility (meters don't go backwards). If the previous reading was entered incorrectly:

1. **Edit** the previous reading (set it to a lower, correct value), or
 2. Delete it (reason required), then re-enter the new reading.
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10. Port already in use

Symptom: Startup error like `ENOTCONN` / `EADDRINUSE` / "address already in use" for port **4000** or **5173** — usually a leftover instance of the app still running.

On macOS/Linux, find what holds the port:

```
lsof -nP -iTCP:4000 -sTCP:LISTEN
lsof -nP -iTCP:5173 -sTCP:LISTEN
```

Kill the listed PID(s), then start fresh:

```
kill <pid> && npm run dev
```

⚠ A stale server is often the exact cause of "old code still running" — restarting from a clean state fixes both the port conflict and missing endpoints at once.